Thursday, November 12, 2026
Memorial

St. Josaphat Kuntsevych

Archbishop of Polotsk, Martyr · Feast, November 12



Martyrdom of Saint Josaphat Kuntsevych, Józef Simmler, c. 1861[1]

1. Józef Simmler, *Martyrdom of Saint Josaphat Kuntsevych*, c. 1861; Wikimedia Commons.

✠ The Essentials

- **Origin:** born in the little town of Volodymyr in Volhynia, then part of Lithuania. His noble Ruthenian family had turned to trade, and his father was a town councilor.[2] [3]
- **Born:** 1580, or 1584 according to some writers.[4]
- **Died:** at Vitebsk, on November 12, 1623, struck down with an axe and a bullet.[5]
- **Feast:** November 12, on the General Roman Calendar.[6]
- **Titles:** Bishop of Vitebsk from 1617 and Archbishop of Polotsk from 1618; martyr. Canonized in 1867.[7] [8]

✠ His Life in Brief

Josaphat was born into a Church divided against itself. After the Union of Berest in 1596 the Ruthenian Church split into two parties: those who accepted union with Rome and those who stayed apart, each with its own bishops.[9]

- He was apprenticed to a merchant at Vilna. In 1604, at twenty-four, he entered the Basilian monastery of the Trinity there.[10] [11]

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2. "St. Josaphat Kuncevyc," in *The Catholic Encyclopedia*, vol. 8 (New York: Robert Appleton Company, 1910).
3. Ibid.
4. Ibid.
5. Ibid.
6. Ibid.
7. Ibid.
8. Ibid.
9. Ibid.
10. Ibid.
11. Ibid.

- He was ordained priest in 1609.[12] On November 12, 1617, he was consecrated Bishop of Vitebsk, against his own wishes, with the right to succeed to the see of Polotsk, which he took up in 1618.[13]
- As archbishop he issued a catechism to his clergy, to be learned by heart.[14]
- Hatred from the party opposed to the union grew year by year. When it became clear he was in danger he refused the chance to flee.[15]
- On November 12, 1623, an axe-stroke and a bullet killed him at Vitebsk.[16] He was beatified in 1643 and canonized in 1867.[17]

✠ Famous Excerpt: Pius XI, *Ecclesiam Dei*

> *"He felt, in fact, that God had inspired him to restore world-wide unity to the Church and he realised that his greatest chance of success lay in preserving the Slavonic rite and Saint Basil's rule of monastic life within the one universal Church."*[18]

Pope Pius XI wrote this in 1923, on the three-hundredth anniversary of the martyrdom. The Church reads it in the Office of Readings on the memorial.[19]

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12. Ibid.
13. Ibid.
14. Ibid.
15. Ibid.
16. Ibid.
17. Ibid.
18. Pius XI, encyclical *Ecclesiam Dei* (November 12, 1923), in the *Liturgy of the Hours*, Office of Readings, Memorial of St. Josaphat, second reading.
19. Ibid.

✠ 1. Catechesis

Lesson: a bishop teaches, and the teaching is learned. In Josaphat's day the clergy around him were unlettered and seldom preached or gave catechetical instruction.[20] As archbishop he issued a catechism for his clergy and told them to learn it by heart.[21]

Exercise: pick one short part of the catechism you could learn by heart this week, and say it each morning.

✠ 2. Apologetics

Objection: "Unity with Rome means giving up your own rite and tradition." Josaphat answered that unity does not require uniformity. He saw that his best hope lay in keeping the Slavonic rite and the monastic rule of St. Basil within the one universal Church.[22] His arguments came mostly from the liturgical books the Eastern Christians already used, which carried the authority of the Fathers.[23] [24] His opponents gave him the nickname "the thief of souls."[25]

✠ 3. Theology

- **Unity and apostolic structure:** Pius XI sees in the apostles a double bond, the inner tie of the same faith and love, and the outer tie of authority, with the primacy given to Peter. In his reading, Josaphat gave his life for that unity.[26]

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20. "St. Josaphat Kuncevyc," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
21. Ibid.
22. Pius XI, *Ecclesiam Dei*.
23. Ibid.
24. "St. Josaphat Kuncevyc," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
25. Pius XI, *Ecclesiam Dei*.
26. Ibid.

- **Liturgy as a source of doctrine:** from his study of the liturgical books he drew many proofs of Catholic truth.[27]
- **Pastoral courage:** he stayed at his post when escape was offered.[28]

✠ 4. Devotional Prayer

Collect, Memorial of St. Josaphat (Roman Missal, November 12):[29]
Stir up in your Church, we pray, O Lord, the Spirit that filled Saint Josaphat as he laid down his life for the sheep, so that through his intercession we, too, may be strengthened by the same Spirit and not be afraid to lay down our life for others. Through our Lord Jesus Christ, your Son, who lives and reigns with you in the unity of the Holy Spirit, one God, for ever and ever. Amen.

His favorite prayer, said with a deep bow of the head to the ground:[30]
Jesus Christ, Son of God, have mercy on me, a poor sinner.

Practice: Say the Jesus Prayer slowly several times today, whenever you are waiting.

✠ Today's Takeaway

Josaphat gave his life for the unity of the Church and the sheep he was sent to feed.[31] [32]

St. Josaphat, pray for us.

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27. "St. Josaphat Kuncevyc," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
28. Ibid.
29. *The Roman Missal*, 3rd typical ed., Memorial of St. Josaphat, Bishop and Martyr (November 12), Collect.
30. "St. Josaphat Kuncevyc," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
31. Pius XI, *Ecclesiam Dei*.
32. *Roman Missal*, Nov. 12, Collect.